CHAPTER 8

LOCAL GOVERNMENTS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Study grassroots democracy, 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendment Acts, three-tier Panchayati Raj, women reservation, State Finance and Election Commissions, and decentralization challenges.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Evolution of Democratic Decentralization:** Rooted in Article 40 of the Directive Principles and Mahatma Gandhi's vision of Gram Swaraj, local self-government evolved through the recommendations of the Balwant Rai Mehta and Ashok Mehta committees.

• **73rd Constitutional Amendment Act (1992):** Created Part IX and the Eleventh Schedule (29 subjects), mandating a uniform three-tier Panchayati Raj system: Gram Panchayat at village level, Panchayat Samiti at intermediate block level, and Zilla Parishad at district level, with the Gram Sabha as the sovereign grassroots assembly.

• **Affirmative Action and Institutional Support:** Mandated 33 percent seat reservations for women across all tiers and leadership posts, along with proportional reservations for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, overseen by an independent State Election Commission and State Finance Commission.

• **74th Amendment and Decentralization Deficits:** Constitutionalized Urban Local Bodies (Nagar Panchayats, Municipal Councils, Municipal Corporations) under Part IX-A and Twelfth Schedule (18 subjects); yet local governance struggles with inadequate devolution of funds, functions, and functionaries.

ESSENTIAL FORMULAS & GOVERNING EQUATIONS

$$\text{Rural Governance} \Leftrightarrow \text{Gram Panchayat (Village)} \rightarrow \text{Panchayat Samiti (Block)} \rightarrow \text{Zilla Parishad (District)}$$

Mandatory vertical structural hierarchy of rural local self-governance

$$\text{Local Autonomy} = \frac{\text{Devolved Finances} \times \text{Administrative Powers} \times \text{Dedicated Personnel}}{\text{Bureaucratic Control}}$$

Interdependent elements essential for meaningful local democratic empowerment

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Elections to Panchayats and Urban Local Bodies are conducted by the autonomous State Election Commission, not by the Central Election Commission of India.

• **Alert:** The 73rd Amendment established a minimum 33 percent reservation for women; states have constitutional authority to increase this quota, and Kerala along with several other states has raised it to 50 percent.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. What is the Gram Sabha and what is its role in grassroots democracy? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Composition:** The Gram Sabha comprises all adult residents registered as voters in the electoral roll of a village panchayat area. **[1 Mark]**

• **Grassroots Role:** Acts as the direct democratic assembly reviewing panchayat budgets, monitoring development projects, and selecting scheme beneficiaries. **[1 Mark]**

2. State any three mandatory provisions introduced by the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Three-Tier Structure:** Mandatory creation of a three-tier Panchayati Raj system in all states with a population exceeding twenty lakhs. **[1 Mark]**

• **Regular Five-Year Elections:** Mandatory direct elections every five years, with fresh elections required within six months if a panchayat is dissolved. **[1 Mark]**

• **Reservation for Women:** Mandatory reservation of not less than one-third (33 percent) of total seats and chairperson positions for women. **[1 Mark]**

3. Describe the three-tier organizational structure of the Panchayati Raj system in India. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Gram Panchayat (Village Level):** Primary tier directly elected by village voters, headed by a Sarpanch or President, managing local sanitation, water, and lighting. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **2. Panchayat Samiti (Block Level):** Intermediate tier coordinating development schemes across a group of village panchayats, linking village and district tiers. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Zilla Parishad (District Level):** Apex rural tier overseeing developmental planning, allocating state resources, and advising state administration across the district. **[1.5 Marks]**

4. Explain how the 73rd and 74th Amendments have transformed women's participation and leadership in rural and urban local bodies. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Massive Numerical Presence:** Mandating 33 percent reservation brought over a million women into elected public leadership positions across India. **[1 Mark]**

• **Leadership at the Helm:** Reservation of chairperson posts enabled women to serve as Sarpanches, Block Presidents, District Panchayat Chiefs, and Mayors. **[1 Mark]**

• **Enhanced State Quotas:** States like Kerala, Bihar, and Madhya Pradesh expanded reservation for women to 50 percent, transforming grassroots governance. **[1 Mark]**

• **Focus on Social Priorities:** Women leaders have prioritized drinking water, child health, girls schooling, public sanitation, and anti-alcohol campaigns. **[1 Mark]**

5. Discuss the institutional roles of the State Election Commission and the State Finance Commission in strengthening local self-government. [Score: 5 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Independent State Election Commission (Article 243K):** Conducts free and fair elections to all rural and urban local bodies across the State. **[1 Mark]**

• **Depoliticizing Election Schedules:** Prevents State governments from arbitrarily delaying or postponing municipal and panchayat elections. **[1 Mark]**

• **State Finance Commission (Article 243I):** Constituted every five years to review the financial position of local bodies and recommend resource allocations. **[1 Mark]**

• **Revenue Devolution:** Recommends distribution of net tax, duty, toll, and fee proceeds between the State Government and local self-governments. **[1 Mark]**

• **Fiscal Viability:** Proposes measures to improve internal revenue mobilization through local taxes, reducing dependence on state grants. **[1 Mark]**

6. Assess the major achievements and lingering challenges of democratic decentralization in India with focus on funds, functions, and functionaries. [Score: 6 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Grassroots Empowerment Achievement:** Created a constitutional third tier of government, broadening democratic citizenship and nurturing grassroots leadership. **[1 Mark]**

• **Inclusion of Marginalized Communities:** Mandated political voice for SCs, STs, and women who were historically excluded from political decision-making. **[1 Mark]**

• **Crisis of Funds:** Most local bodies lack independent revenue sources and depend heavily on tied state and central grants, restricting local initiative. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Reluctance to Transfer Functions:** State departments often resist transferring real legislative and operational authority over the 29 Eleventh Schedule subjects. **[1 Mark]**

• **Lack of Trained Functionaries:** Panchayats frequently suffer from staffing shortages, lack of technical personnel (engineers, accountants), and bureaucratic domination. **[1 Mark]**

• **The Kerala Model Exception:** The People's Plan Campaign in Kerala demonstrated successful decentralization by devolving substantial funds and administrative powers directly to local bodies. **[0.5 Mark]**